purposes of sending envoys and royal edicts, and in emergencies.' And indeed one of Akbar's great achievements was the standardization of measurement of area. For measuring distances, the kos was used.[†]

Six days later, the camp reached Delhi, described by Monserrate as studded with 'lofty and handsomely decorated residences' and broad and imposing streets 'planted down the middle with beautiful green trees which cast a grateful shade'. On either side of the fickle Yamuna, which would one day abandon these glorious buildings, were stately mansions and parks dense with fruits and flowers. Akbar went to visit Humayun's tomb and met his beloved stepmother, Bega Begum, who lived in the Arab Sarai quarters. When he visited his father's tomb, Akbar would have had an aching and visceral reminder of Humayun's physical presence. The tomb at that time would have been richly decorated with carpets and tapestries while an awning would have covered the central shrine itself. Within the chamber of the tomb would have been Humayun's Koran, dagger, sword, turban, and shoes, as if the Padshah had only just left the room. All these priceless mementos would quietly disappear after the British took back Delhi following the chaos of the 1857 Uprising.

In Delhi Akbar was shown incriminating letters that proved his powerful finance minister, Shah Mansur, was colluding with Mirza Hakim. Shah Mansur had begun his career as an accountant in the Perfume Department and, as so often happened in Akbar's meritocratic system, worked his way up through talent and ambition to become wazir. Though the veracity of these letters was later doubted, Shah Mansur was a deeply unpopular man for the brusque, tactless, and over-zealous way in which he carried out his affairs. Even Todar Mal, Akbar's exemplary officer, complained of his high-handedness, talking of his 'sharp letters…claiming a good deal of money'. Akbar was therefore constrained to publicly execute Shah Mansur, though 'the King's mournful countenance plainly showed how much pained he had been by the wretched man's fate' and the loss of a supremely efficient officer.

The execution of Shah Mansur, so troubling to Akbar, was part of the vital dispensation of justice which was carried out even while the court was on the move. The Jesuits had noted Akbar's great concern with the proper rule of law and wrote that 'the King has the most precise regard for right and justice in the affairs of government'. Cases were usually brought forward before two judges but 'by the King's direction all capital cases, and